



The Great Lakes

Earth's largest system of freshwater lakes, often referred to as inland seas

North America's Great Lakes have a combined surface area of 94,000 square miles (244,000 square km)—exceeding that of the UK—and contain one-fifth of the world's fresh surface water. The system comprises five interconnected lakes—Superior, Michigan, Huron, Erie, and Ontario—draining from west to east and emptying into the Atlantic Ocean via the St. Lawrence River. Although the gradient between the lakes is generally shallow, the descent between Lakes Erie and Ontario features the dramatic Niagara Falls (see p.52).

Diverse shorelines

The Great Lakes began to form at the end of the last ice age, when moving ice sheets gouged huge basins that subsequently filled with water as the ice melted. The current shapes of the lakes started to become established about 10,000 years ago. Their shorelines vary considerably, from sandy beaches to rocky cliffs, and even wetlands. Also located on their shores are several major cities including Toronto, Chicago, Cleveland, Buffalo, and Detroit.

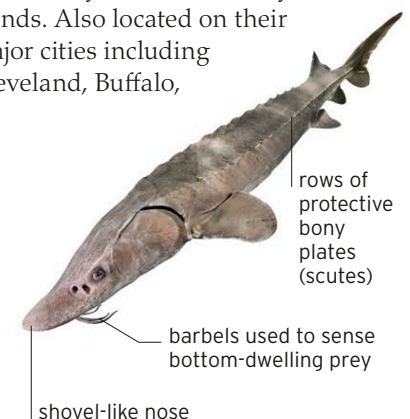


◀ ONE OF THOUSANDS

The lakes contain 35,000 islands, ranging in size from 10 feet wide—as shown here in Lake Superior—to several thousand square miles in area.

▷ LARGEST NATIVE

The lake sturgeon is the largest of more than 150 native fish species in the Great Lakes, growing to about 6 ft (2 m) in length and weighing 200 lb (90 kg) or more.



rows of protective bony plates (scutes)

barbels used to sense bottom-dwelling prey

shovel-like nose

The **inland** U.S. state of **Michigan** has **more coastline** than California or **Florida**